

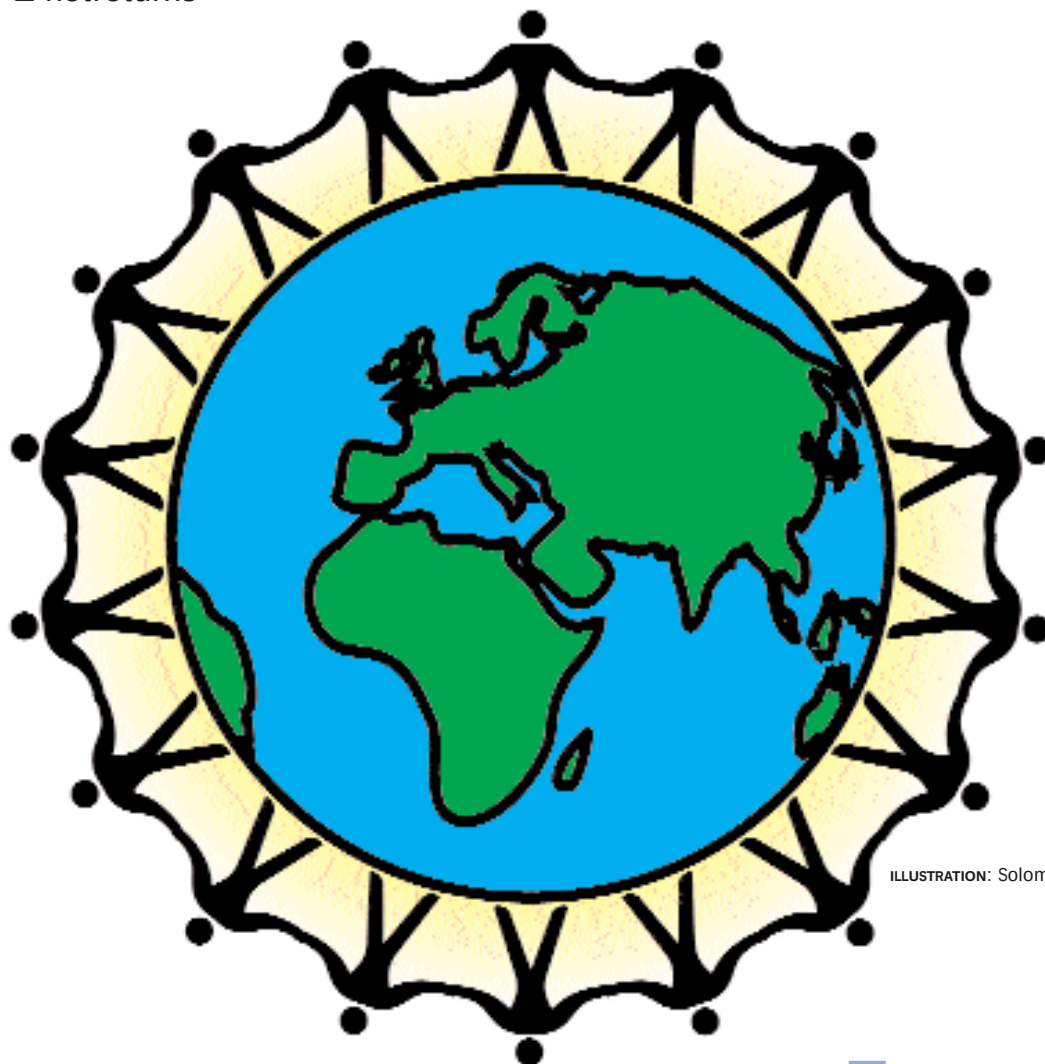


ILLUSTRATION: Solomon Lewis

Dot comUnity

Reach out to likeminded people online and share
your thoughts and ideas beyond the limitations of geography and time

An anonymous parent at the nephrology web (www.healthboards.com) quells his apprehensions about the immunosuppressant medications that her child is taking. Meanwhile, in the forums on *Gigpad*, Manowar is raving mad about the fact that Megadeth has broken up—"Let us not forget that the often forgotten Megadeth has sold more albums than Guns N' Roses". He falls into a dispute with Nolan, who insists that AC/DC is a mediocre rock band that

no one cares for. Anuradha logs in daily into her favourite newsgroup and networks with likeminded students on preparing for her Masters degree abroad. She finds out information on everything—admission processes, visa formalities and prospective roommates. The community section of *vault.com* helps jobseekers and employees of a company. At *f***edcompany.com*, a community that rose out of the dotcom crash, people are busy documenting the dotcom deadpool on a daily basis.

So what is an online community? A drop-in centre? A support group? A social network or a professional society? Online communities can be all of these. "I use mail and MSN Messenger service to keep in touch with my friends. But at a larger level, I love sharing my thoughts at forums and discussion boards. We started a close-knit e-group called Infopimps at Yahoo! e-groups. We're likeminded individuals, discussing current issues, books, and various other topics that crop

